FORGE

Facilitating Opportunities for Reentry, Growth & Empowerment

A Peer-Led Mentorship Program at Dooly State Prison

FORGE is a 36-week, evidence-based program that trains incarcerated men to become certified peer mentors — reducing dorm conflict, strengthening rehabilitation programming, and building a safer facility for inmates and staff alike.

What FORGE Does

FORGE prepares men to facilitate evidence-based programs, mediate conflicts, lead restorative circles, and model accountability across housing units. Mentors operate within clearly defined boundaries — they do not investigate incidents, impose discipline, or replace staff authority.

The program creates a **self-sustaining pipeline**: certified mentors from each cohort train the next, building permanent infrastructure.

How It Benefits Staff

Fewer conflicts — Mentors de-escalate before incidents occur.
Stronger programming — RISE and Pathfinders get trained facilitators.
More stable dorms — Peer accountability and a culture of restraint.
Clear boundaries — Mentors support staff authority, never undermine it.

The 36-Week Curriculum

108 sessions. 3 per week. 2 hours each. Three phases with formal gate requirements:

Phase 1: Foundation
Weeks 1–12
"Know Yourself" — CBT, emotional regulation, conflict resolution

Phase 2: Development
Weeks 13–24
"Build Others" — Facilitation, MI, simulation training

Phase 3: Practicum
Weeks 25–36
"Lead & Serve" — Supervised mentoring, 60+ hrs, certification

Built on Evidence That Works

Curriculum from **Thinking for a Change** (NIC), **Moral Reconation Therapy**, **GRIP** (California), **Seeking Safety**, **SAMHSA Trauma-Informed Framework**. Structure from **PEP** (Texas), **RSVP** (San Francisco), **Defy Ventures**, **Oregon Mentors Certification Program**.

0.5%	80%	43%	$5 : $1	85%
GRIP recidivism (vs. 41.9% state avg)	Reduction in violent rearrests (RSVP)	Less likely to recidivate (RAND meta-analysis)	Return on investment (RAND Corporation)	Employment within 6 months (Defy)

What Participants Learn

Phase 1: Personal Development

- Identify and interrupt thinking errors (CBT)
- Manage emotions using the escalation curve
- 4-4-4 breathing & 5-4-3-2-1 grounding
- Assertive communication & "I" statements
- FORGE 5-step conflict resolution model
- Accountability spectrum & impact awareness
- Growth mindset & future visioning

Phase 2: Mentor Skills

- Adult learning principles & lesson planning
- Motivational interviewing (OARS framework)
- Simulation-based scenario training
- Restorative justice circles
- Crisis de-escalation protocols
- Co-facilitation practice with peer feedback
- Ethics, boundaries & confidentiality

Phase 3: Field Leadership

- Supervised co-facilitation of Phase 1 sessions
- 1-on-1 mentoring with new participants
- Independent session delivery (observed)
- Community circle facilitation
- Real-time conflict mediation
- Self-care & burnout prevention
- Review board & formal certification

The Self-Sustaining Mentor Pipeline

Cohort 1 — Trained by program founders
→
Cohort 1 Graduates — Become certified mentors
→
Train Cohort 2 — Co-facilitate Phase 1 for next group
→
Cycle Repeats — Permanent mentor infrastructure

Accountability & Standards

- **Zero tolerance** for weapons, violence, intimidation, gang signaling
- **Code of Conduct** governs behavior in class, in the dorm, everywhere
- **Peer evaluation** at every phase gate — your cohort holds you accountable
- **Staff observation** required for advancement — no concerns = no advancement
- **Removal** for violations protects program integrity and facility safety

Standard 2-Hour Session

10m Check-in	10m Review	40 min — Core Instruction	30 min — Practice / Exercise	20m — Debrief	10m Checko

Every session follows the same structure: connection, review, learning, practice, reflection, and assignment. Consistency builds discipline.

Program at a Glance

216	12-15	60+	790+
Hours	**Cohort**	**Field Hrs**	**Pages**
108 sessions over 36 weeks	Small groups for accountability	Supervised mentoring	Facilitator guides & workbooks

Statistics from source programs. Full program details in the FORGE Program Overview at forgementors.org

Leadership is not assigned. It is forged.

Positive Outreach Development Society, Inc.
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